

Life *in* the COLONY



Secrets of survival

LIVING IN LARGE GROUPS can have advantages, but to live with thousands or even *millions of your own species* requires a special set of rules. Many insect species live and work together in order to survive. Welcome to life in a colony.

SUPERORGANISMS

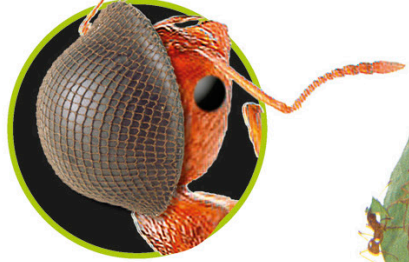
Animals that live together year round in a colony are highly organized and have a strict hierarchy. Each individual is like a cell within a larger creature. Animals that live like this are described as eusocial organisms. Operating as one “superorganism” has certain advantages. By spreading out the responsibilities of life—building a home, fighting off enemies, and looking for a mate—the colony can grow large and survive for decades.

Most colonies have the same structure: at the top is a *single female*, usually called the *queen*. The lower orders are made up of mainly female *workers* and *soldiers*. The members of the colony are usually closely related. Only the *queen* will breed; the workers are sterile. There are a *few males* in the colony *to mate* with the queen.



Some ant colonies have survived for hundreds of years.

Ant army



Leafcutter ants live in impressively large colonies, sometimes numbering millions of individuals.

Each colony consists of a long-lived queen attended by female workers who raise the queen's young. There are different ranks of workers who have particular jobs—chewing up leaves brought back by scouting parties, tending the fungus they cultivate on the chewed leaves, and harvesting the fungus and feeding it to the larvae. The whole nest is guarded by a troop of soldiers, who are much larger than the workers and have powerful jaws to bite through intruders.

